A few words about the current threats facing Israel. In my understanding, Hezbollah in the north and Hamas in the Gaza Strip are at the top of the IDF's priorities within Israel's inner circle of threats. ISIS threatens the Middle East and the world at large. Iran, today and in the foreseeable future, continues to constitute the biggest strategic threat to the State of Israel.

Back to the Second Lebanon War and its aftermath. In my view, the most important and significant achievement of the war was the breaking of the balance of fear that had been established between Hezbollah and the IDF along the Lebanese border, and the return of the IDF's deterrent capability. Proof of this is that, in the eleven years since the Second Lebanon War, Hezbollah has not dared disrupt the quiet along the shared border. To complete the picture of the balance of fear, one must add another aspect. Hezbollah did not stand alone against the IDF. It was supported by Iran and Syria, each of whom saw Hezbollah as its long arm against Israel, and in Iran's case, also against the US. Iran and Syria thought they were maintaining a threatening Hezbollah force along Israel's northern border that would operate only according to their directions and needs. The dynamics on the ground flew in the face of this working assumption when the July 12, 2006, incident initiated by Hezbollah spun out of its control and developed into a war that lasted more than a month.

About a year after the war, the renowned commentator Tom Friedman wrote his own balance sheet of this war. It is fitting for our purposes to quote a few words from his commentary:

> On July 12, 2006, Hezbollah fighters directed by Mr. Nasrallah abducted two Israeli soldiers and killed eight others in an unprovoked attack across the Lebanon-Israel border, on the pretext of seeking a prisoner exchange. This triggered a war that killed about 1,200 Lebanese. . . . Mr. Nasrallah [is] guilty of a serious failure of judgment. . . . Mr. Nasrallah demonstrated a total failure to anticipate Israel's response to his raid. He assumed Israel would carry out the same limited retaliation it had with previous raids. Wrong. He failed to take into account the changed circumstances in Israel. The kidnapping of an Israeli soldier in Gaza a few weeks earlier, plus the fact that a new chief of staff of the Israeli Army, a new prime minister and a new defense minister had just taken office and all felt they were being tested, triggered an enormous Israeli response. Some 1,200 Lebanese died because of this gross error in judgment. . . . In unilaterally launching a war against Israel, without a vote of the Lebanese cabinet—of which Hezbollah is a member—the militia did grievous harm to Lebanon's fragile democracy and democratization in the Arab world. All the fears that if you let an Islamist party into government it will not respect the rules of the game were fulfilled by Hezbollah.[5]